

Treating soil

A farmer applies agricultural lime, which is made from finely ground limestone, onto the soil on a farm in Merseyside, UK. This raises the pH of the too-acidic soil so that it is closer to a neutral pH of 7, helping crops grow better.



IMPROVING THE SOIL

NEUTRALIZING ACIDS

Not all soil is the same—in some areas, it is more acidic than others. The chemical opposite to an acid is an alkali, and when these are added together, they neutralize each other. Because most plants grow best in soil that is neither too acidic or alkaline, sometimes farmers and gardeners add something alkaline, such as lime, to acidic soil. Mixing in lime not only neutralizes the soil, it also helps plants absorb nutrients. Worms and certain microorganisms needed for good soil also dislike acidic conditions, so it encourages them.